

This again

NOSTALGIA IS A FUNNY THING. It's been discussed in depth multiple times over the last few centuries. From the time the word was coined back in the 17th century to describe a psychological condition affecting Swiss soldiers who were anxious and longed to go back home, to more contemporary discussions revolving around the resurgence of technology that was invented a few decades ago, the whole concept has yo-yoed from being a negative aspect to a positive aspect and so on, repeating the same pattern, over and over and over.

Just the other day as I went about writing one of these articles in the magazine, I couldn't help but hum the jingle associated with the Mongol race in Age of Empires II. Upon realising where I'd picked it up, my mind was immediately flooded with all the wonderful memories of playing the game. AoE II is iconic and stands strong as an example of what RTS games should be like but after 20 years, there have been plenty of other titles that I could remember. And yet I went back to a time when things were simple.

Manish, the SKOAR! Warlord who also happens to have a degree in psychology, believes that humans love the comforts of the known and that makes them wax nostalgic frequently. This whole fascination with retro culture sits along the same lines. However, there's also the fact that

humans tend to remember more of the happier memories. It's not like everything was fine and dandy back when you were a kid but you're more likely to fixate on the positives. In contrast to your older memories, your more recent memories which have a good mix of positive and negative, don't appear to evoke the same warmth. So it's only natural to chase after the better times. What's interesting to observe is one's reaction upon reliving "those good times".

Back when I'd suffered my very first bout of AoE II nostalgia, I had gone through the entire game from start to end but with the more recent ones I've stayed away from reliving the entire experience. It's because I've gotten used to better things, better game mechanics, Quality of Life improvements which have become the norm and so on. There now exists the fear that I might lose out on the fond memories should I have a not so good wonderful walk down memory lane with what is arguably one of my favourites. If nostalgia is to be followed by feelings of regret, I'm not so certain this is something I want to experience over and over again. **d**



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